

using the emulator, then you need to obtain a license for the same.

Today's Linux distributions are well equipped with tools and applications to woo both home and office users. Contrary to popular belief, everything that comes with Linux is not free. Some applications, such as Crossover office are shareware.

How and what we tested

We looked for ease of use, right from the OS installation to automounting disks and attaching USB devices, and ease of interoperability with Windows. Everyone has used Windows, and is familiar with the ease of use it offers. So, a Linux distribution must do well against Windows as well.

Another important thing is the application bundle for the most commonly performed tasks. We checked to ensure that a good MS Office replacement was present as well as other business and communication tools.

In any office, the computer rarely sits alone. It is essential that a Linux-based PC behave well on the network in making its resources available, and in accessing the resources of other PCs on the network. Similarly, support for printers and sharing installed printers is very important. Not all distributions do well on this front, varying considerably in device support and software simplicity.

All tests were conducted on an Intel Pentium 4 1.7 GHz processor (Intel motherboard) with 256 MB RD-RAM, an ASUS TNT2 VGA card, onboard Network, a Seagate Barracuda 40 GB, 7,200 RPM hard drive, and an 8x Lite-on DVD Writer.

We tested six flavours of Linux: ELX BizDesktop, Lycoris Desktop/LX, Mandrake 10 Official, RHEL Professional WS, SuSE 9.1 Pro and Xandros Standard. We also tested three LIVE CDs: Knoppix LIVE CD, MandrakeMove and SuSE.

DESKTOP LINUX Starting out

All installations use a three-pane interface for the installation process, with the left pane broadly listing the steps involved in the entire process, and the right pane shows a slide show highlighting the important features of the product. The bottom pane shows description about the current status of the installation process.

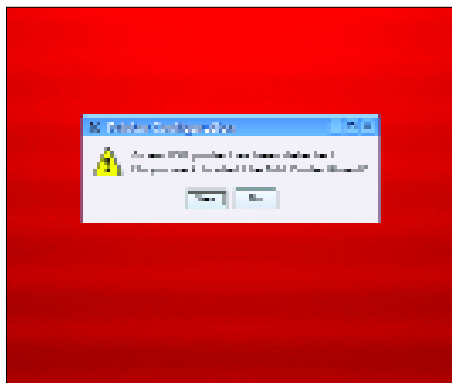
ELX lets you test the installation media, CD or DVD, before you begin

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the install—this reduces the chances of the installation failing. The older Red Hat 9 and the current Fedora Core 2 provide this option, but the Enterprise product we tested does not.

Once the package selection is done, Red Hat lists the distribution CDs needed to complete the install—for example, the 'Personal Desktop' install requires the first



Plugging in a USB device results in a popup notification, in Xandros

and the second CD. Similarly SuSE shows the CDs needed, as well as the amount of time each CD will take to install.

Partitioning

Partitioning the hard drive is the biggest hurdle. For a brand new hard disk with nothing on it, the 'use free space' option is your best bet. This option has two parts to it—auto and manual. The manual option is complicated and not recommended for new users. Some OSes such as RHEL, ELX Biz Desktop, and Lycoris Desktop/LX also provide a way to review the partitions after the auto partitioning is complete.

Mandrake gives you the added option of resizing your Windows partition. You can reduce the size of the Windows partition, up to the limit of free space available, and then use the free space to create partitions for Linux. This option is especially useful for those who do not have free unallocated space on their hard drive. We had a 50 per cent success ratio with it—when we resized a Windows partition it was a success, but when we resized a Xandros Linux partition, it was destroyed!

Type of installation

Generally, most of the distributions provide only a default (also called express or standard) and a Custom option. Mandrake does not provide any install option



Running Windows Applications on a Linux Box

There are a few Windows emulators, which provide an environment in which Windows-based programs can be executed on a Linux platform. All you need to do is load the emulator in Linux. A few such emulators are Wine, Crossover Office and VMWare.

Wine is an open source implementation that can be downloaded for free from www.winehq.com. It runs the Win 32 and Win 16 API on Linux. Hence, you can execute almost all your Win 32, Win 16 or DOS applications. It provides X11-based graphical support, DirectX support, as well as a text-based console. Support for sound devices, input devices, printing devices, scanners and CD writers, are also included. Even bug detection occurs similar to a Windows PC.

Crossover Office has a small set of applications that can be emulated on Linux. The list of applications supported includes Microsoft Office, Lotus

Notes, Microsoft Visio, etc. Its latest version, CrossOver Office 2.0.1, is available at <http://www.codeweavers.com/products/office/>.

VMware takes advantage of the Intel architecture, which allows virtual machines to be created at the hardware level, enabling you to use more than one operating system on the same PC. It establishes a virtual network connection between the operating systems, allowing them to communicate with each other as if they were physical computers, connected via the LAN. So, you can access the Linux virtual machine via Network Neighborhood in Windows, and vice versa. The biggest advantage is that it can have either Linux, or Windows as the host operating system.

Though Wine is free, the bad news is that the other two aren't. Wine is installed automatically with the ELX install, but not in SuSE. Xandros steers clear of wine or CrossOver Office.